

Soitec

Feedback from call: Growing management confidence on Photonics demand and supply, revenue accelerating through the year

Soitec management hosted a conference call this morning following the pre-announced Q1 sales results, with positive messaging and tone on the Photonics business, both on customer demand and Soitec's ability to supply. Management is indicating that Photonics revenue should grow sequentially through fiscal '27 as supply comes online and customer demand accelerates. FY27 revenue estimates are likely to move higher on Photonics (although Mobile Communications was weaker than consensus expected) with flow through to earnings. However, our sense is that outer year group level forecasts should not change significantly, with our investor conversations suggesting FY30E Photonics revenues are already comfortably above €500m.

- **Accelerating Photonics demand.** Management indicated that the majority of the current demand it is seeing in Photonics relates to scale-out pluggables with an increasing portion of Near-Packaged Optics. Co-Packaged Optics is expected to begin to ramp towards the end of FY27, while scale-up interconnect is beginning to be seen in demand. Management commentary suggested that pricing remains favourable given the strong demand, although Capacity Reservation Agreements would come with lower pricing.
- **Improving visibility and confidence on Photonics.** Management noted that Capacity Reservation Agreements are being structured in order to give the company greater confidence in Photonics demand beyond FY27, given: (i) requirement of customer pre-payment or deposit to secure volumes (reducing the risk of double ordering), and (ii) Soitec gains insight into customer inventory levels (reducing the risk of overstocking the channel). Management did not indicate what level of revenue the Capacity Reservation Agreements represents; however, the prepayment balance (reported at H1) may provide a helpful indication. On the FY27 guide, management accepted that a portion of the Photonics revenue related to building a buffer ahead of expected production ramps.
- **Ramping Photonics supply.** A significant driver of the Photonics-SOI guidance upgrade seems to be the acceleration of the first customer qualification at the Singapore facility (300mm). This was originally expected towards the end of calendar 2026, but has been accelerated, with management noting that further qualifications are underway. Management noted that it is asking customers to qualify with both Bernin, France and Singapore supply if they are to receive increased volumes (the facilities are equivalent so the additional qualification is not onerous).
- **RF-SOI inventory digestion tracking well.** Management estimates RF-SOI customer inventories stand at ~1.7m (200mm equivalent) at the end of June quarter, down from ~2.0m at the end of March quarter. Hence the company continues to track to the 200-300k undershipping per quarter. The company is benefiting from growing 300mm RF-SOI sales, where it enjoys higher market share compared to 200mm.

Neutral

SOIT.PA, SOI FP
Price (22 Jul 26):€96.02

Price Target (Dec-27):€92.00

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- **Gross margin dynamics.** With the improving revenue momentum, management has increased fab loading guidance for FY27 to ~65% (from ~60%) with the ramp expected from Q2 (following ~48% loading in Q1). In addition, strength in Photonics is expected to positively impact group-level mix and price in FY27, even offsetting lower pricing tied to long-term agreements and higher bulk wafer costs (management indicated that it expects slight contribution margin expansion in FY27). On headwinds, management indicated that the headwind from lower government funding would be ~€30m (higher than the ~€20m we had previously expected). On profitability, CFO Jacquemont stated that *“we expect that recovery to be tangible and significant in 2027 and to fully materialize in 2028”*.

Investment Thesis, Valuation and Risks

Soitec (*Neutral; Price Target: €92.00*)

Investment Thesis

Soitec is going through a period of extreme inventory correction at customers, which is having a significant negative impact on revenue. At the same time, concerns over the competition for Soitec's largest product (RF-SOI) are heightened. Other products are beginning to compensate, notably POI and Photonics-SOI, which we expect to become the dominant revenue stream in the next 2-3 years. Market enthusiasm for Silicon Photonics has resulted in a significant run-up in the shares; however, we now see the valuation as full to fair, reflecting the future opportunity.

Valuation

Our Dec-27 price target of €92 is based on 11.0x FY29e EBITDA (y/e March 2029) (previously €130 valued on 15.0x FY29). The chosen multiple is at the high end of the wafer maker range, justified by higher growth; the multiple is a ~10% premium to the last five-year average, justified by improving growth, returns and cash flow. We value on FY29 earnings, which we expect to be more normalised following a period of depressed financial performance (in FY26 and expected/guided in FY27).

Risks to Rating and Price Target

Key upside risks to our rating/price target include:

- Better-than-expected growth in Silicon Photonics
- Stabilisation of market share in RF-SOI post inventory correction.
- Better-than-expected smartphone recovery and adoption of FD-SOI across 5G smartphone mmWave, automotive and IoT applications.
- New high volume customer wins for POI product offering.
- Better-than-expected improvement in operating margin and free cash flow generation on the back of management action.

Key downside risks:

- Heightened competition in RF-SOI leading to more rapid market share loss (in particular from Global Wafers)
- More rapid market share loss in SiPho, most likely from Global Wafers
- No normalisation of inventory levels.
- Initiatives to improve working capital may have a detrimental impact on revenue/market share and profitability.

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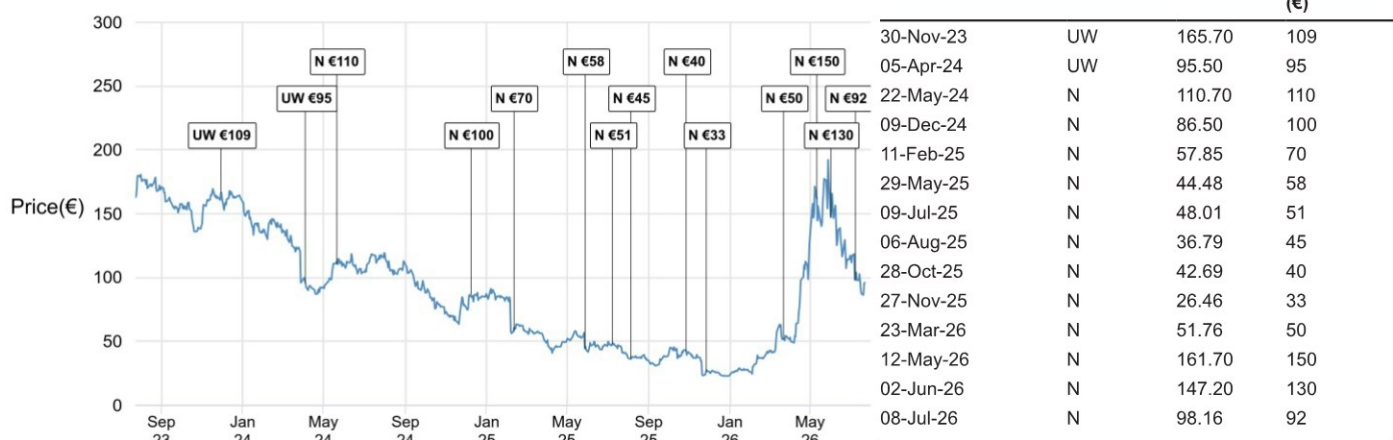
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Soitec (SOIT.PA, SOI FP) Price Chart



Source: Bloomberg Finance L.P. and J.P. Morgan; price data adjusted for stock splits and dividends.
Initiated coverage Jan 18, 2007. All share prices are as of market close on the previous business day.

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